

CINDERELLA SARAH

Sarah is an executive in her late fifties. Her parents were affluent. Her father started his own business when she was quite young. When we interviewed her, Sarah was extremely candid about her relationship with her “Papa” and sister.

Sarah’s father was a very strong-willed individual. His views about the role of women in our society were at odds with Sarah’s. He felt that women should be educated in the fine arts and then marry, have children, and never work outside the home. Women, according to Papa’s dictates, were not to have careers of their own. They were to be supportive—even subservient—to their husbands.

As a teenager, Sarah enjoyed debating Papa on numerous topics, including the role of liberated women in our culture. Often these debates turned into arguments centered on how Sarah would spend the rest of her life. Papa frequently threatened his defiant daughter with the loss of financial support for her college education, dowry, and so forth.

In spite of these threats, Sarah left home when she was a young woman. Her papa made good on his promise and withheld all financial support. Yet Sarah never lost her determination to become financially and emotionally independent from her parents. After leaving home, she became a proofreader for a large publishing company. During her career in the publishing industry, she rose to a very senior position. Eventually she married, but only after her own career was well established.

Sarah was distinctly different from her sister, Alice. Unlike Sarah, Alice, a Type B housewife, filled the role that Papa had assigned her. She was clearly “Papa’s girl.” Papa’s girl married a local gentleman, a fellow from a lower social stratum who had a high propensity to spend but little propensity to earn an income. In light of this fact, Papa placed Alice, her low-income-producing husband, and their three children on his own special brand of financial outpatient care. Papa would never allow his favorite daughter to live in a home or neighborhood that was incongruent with his own upper-middle-class image. He heavily subsidized the purchase of a home and accessories for Alice and her family. Significant cash gifts and gifts of securities were bestowed upon “Papa’s girl” annually.

Given these liberal subsidies, one might predict that Papa’s girl would have accumulated a considerable amount of wealth. In fact, she and her husband accumulated very little money during all the years they were on